CLIMATE CONSCIOUS

AADITYA THACKERAY, 31

Minister of Tourism & Environment, Maharashtra

The first member of the Thackeray clan to have contested and won elections, Balasaheb's grandson and Uddhav and Rashmi Thackeray's elder son has infused a constructive energy in the state's politics. The law and history graduate shares next-gen's concern about climate change and wants political parties to adopt it as a poll plank, something he reiterated while launching the curriculum for environment education—*Majhi Vasundhara*—on December 13. His commitment to the cause became apparent during the Devendra Fadnavis-led regime, when he was keenly involved in the initiative to ban single-use plastic in the state.

Later, when he took over as environment minister in the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi government led by his father, the first thing he did was to add climate change to the name of his department. His effort to introduce electric vehicles on Mumbai's roads also stems from this concern. Nor was it a surprise when young Thackeray turned up at the global climate change conference in UK in September.

Climate change, however, is not the only thing close to his heart. And no, we are not talking about his love of words—Aaditya is a published poet and has also cut his own album, for which he wrote all its eight songs.

Thackeray Jr is also brimming with ideas for tourism in his state. For one, he has cut down the number of permissions required to set up a hotel from 70 to 10. His emphasis on promoting agro tourism, adventure tourism, caravans and branding tourist destinations have seen massive infrastructure development across the state. Next on his agenda are the 400 forts, beaches and wildlife in the state. "Maharashtra has everything except sand and snow to attract tourists across the world. We need to market them appropriately"—is his unstated mandate to officials of the tourism department. And what better way to marry his twin preoccupations—environment and tourism—than to train locals in tourist spots on how they can save the environment while promoting tourism.

Aaditya is equally interested in the planning and execution of infrastructure works in Mumbai. It is not unusual to find him inspecting the progress of the Sewri-Nhava Sheva Sea Link one day and huddling with Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority officials the next. He wants to make Mumbai traffic jam-free by December 2023. Umeed was not just the name of his first album. Hope is something Thackeray Jr is heavily invested in. ■

– Kiran D. Tare

VALUE AD Fond of writing, Aaditya often helps create content for his party's campaign hoardings. Loves reading and watching cricket, especially Test matches